

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 4 · FRAME

Where the film puts things, and what it leaves out.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

The Grand Budapest Hotel · 2014 · 99 min · written and directed
by Wes Anderson · Fox Searchlight

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

Two filmmakers who never put anything in the frame by accident, using that control for opposite reasons. Wes Anderson puts the most important thing dead centre and builds the world around it like a dollhouse. Wong Kar-wai pushes his lovers to the edges, behind doors, into corridors and mirrors, and leaves the middle of the frame empty.

One frame shows you everything. The other hides half of it. Both are breaking the same rule, from opposite sides.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

THE GRAND BUDAPEST HOTEL

2014 · 99 min · written and directed by Wes Anderson · Fox Searchlight

A legendary hotel concierge and his teenage lobby boy are framed for murder in a made-up European country, just as war arrives. A caper, a prison break and a ski chase, told as a story inside a story inside a story.

Why it is on the ballot. No filmmaker working today is more recognisable from a single frame. Anderson centres, balances and flattens every shot, and in this film he changes the actual shape of the screen three times. It is the easiest film in the world to pause and study.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE SCREEN CHANGES SHAPE THREE TIMES

Anderson and cinematographer Robert Yeoman shot three ratios for three eras: the near-square Academy frame, 1.37:1, for 1932; wide 2.35:1 anamorphic for 1968; and standard 1.85:1 for the 1985 and present-day bookends. Watch the black bars at the edge of your screen move.

THE HOTEL IS A MODEL, AND THE LOBBY IS A DEPARTMENT STORE

The pink hotel on the hill is a 1:18-scale miniature built by Atelier Simon Weisse in Berlin. The lobby was built inside a disused 1912 department store in Görlitz, Germany, near the Polish border, which stood in for most of the fictional country.

IT IS DEDICATED TO A WRITER

The credits say the film was “inspired by the writings of Stefan Zweig,” an Austrian novelist hugely popular before the Second World War who fled Europe as it collapsed. No single book is adapted.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE FIRST JUMP BACK IN TIME

The bars close in

When the film arrives in 1932 the picture shrinks to a near square.

Why it matters: The frame itself tells you what year it is. The past is literally narrower. Anderson has said the taller frame also “sees ceilings a lot more,” which is why the 1932 interiors feel capped and boxed.

ANY LOBBY SCENE

Find the centre

Pick any shot of Gustave in the hotel and look at the middle of the screen. Something important is almost always sitting there: a face, a door, a lift, a cake.

Why it matters: Centred frames feel controlled and slightly unreal, like a stage. That is exactly who Gustave is.

WHENEVER THE CAMERA MOVES

Straight lines only

The camera whip-pans hard left or right, tilts straight up or down, or tracks sideways. It almost never drifts.

Why it matters: Moving in right angles keeps the frame flat, like the pages of a picture book.

THE SKI CHASE

The film admits it is a toy

The mountain chase mixes stop-motion figures, miniature bobsled runs and model gondolas with matte paintings, and does not hide it.

Why it matters: The film is honest about being made. Ask whether that makes the danger feel smaller, or more like a memory.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

[OPEN](#)

Four storytellers, three frames

A girl at the Author's monument in the present, the Author in 1985, the young Author at the hotel in 1968, and Zero's story in 1932. Each layer sits in its own period, and the aspect ratio tracks it.

[OPEN](#)

The square frame is a piece of real history

The 1932 ratio is the Academy aperture, adopted by the American studios in 1931 and codified by the Academy the following year. Anderson shot the past in the shape the past was actually shot in.

[OPEN](#)

Four Oscars, all for building the world

From nine nominations it won Production Design, Costume Design, Makeup and Hairstyling, and Alexandre Desplat's score. Nothing for the acting or the script. The awards went to the frame.

- 01 Everything is centred and symmetrical. Did that make you feel calm, or trapped? Is there a moment where it stops working?
- 02 The frame gets wider as the story gets later. What does the film think happened to the world between 1932 and 1968?
- 03 Is the prettiness hiding what the film is about, or is it how the film grieves?

Where to watch

Find it here → [The Grand Budapest Hotel on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Slate · the Design Museum · Variety · AWN

DIVIDE BY THREE

AN ENGRAVER DESCRIBED A HABIT

In 1797 an English engraver named John Thomas Smith published *Remarks on Rural Scenery*, about painting landscapes. He noticed painters tended to divide a picture in proportions of about two thirds to one third — how much sky against how much land — and named it, with an apology: “Analogous to this ‘Rule of thirds,’ (if I may be allowed so to call it) I have presumed to think that, in connecting or in breaking the various lines of a picture, it would likewise be a good rule to do it, in general, by a similar scheme of proportion.”

THE CAMERA MADE IT A LAW

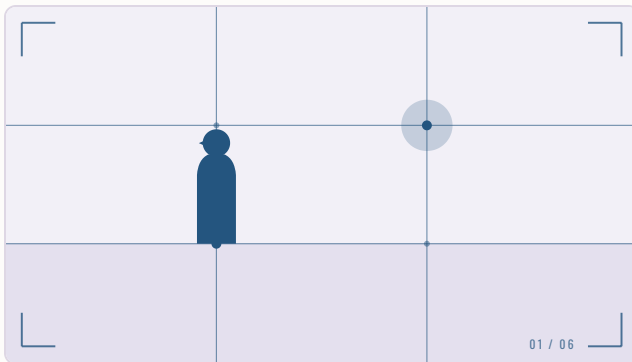
Photography manuals picked it up, film schools taught it, and eventually cameras and phones drew the grid onto the screen itself. Put the subject on a line, never in the middle. A tentative note about landscape painting became the first thing every beginner is told about the frame.

AND THE SCREEN ITSELF GOT A SHAPE

The American studios adopted the Academy aperture in 1931 and the Academy codified it the next year, giving the near-square 1.37:1 frame. When television arrived in the 1950s, cinema went wide to compete, and the frame has been changing shape ever since. The Grand Budapest Hotel uses that history as a clock.

SIX WAYS TO ARRANGE A FRAME

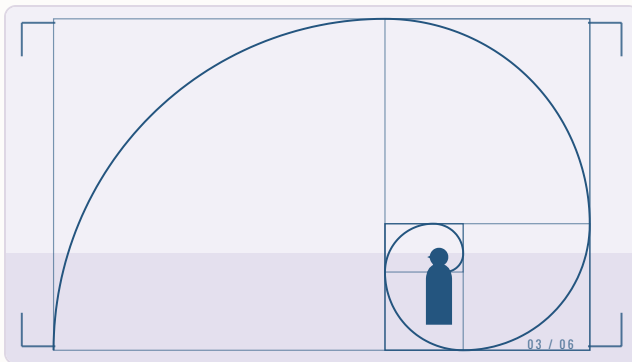
Centuries of painting and a century of cinema have trained the eye to read some arrangements as natural and others as deliberate, and how much of that is culture and how much is instinct is a different debate. Altering any of them is not a mistake, it is a different effect. The one thing worth holding onto is that where a film puts things changes what you feel about them, whether anyone meant it to or not.



THIRDS

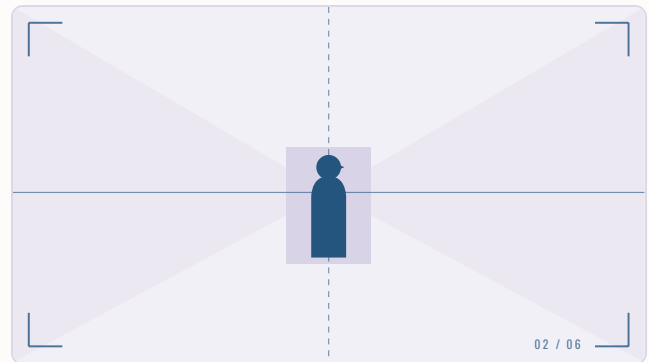
Two vertical lines and two horizontal lines divide the frame into a three by three grid. Whatever matters sits on one of those lines, or on one of the four points where they cross. To spot it, look at where a face or a horizon lands: on a line, not in the middle.

Almost everything



GOLDEN SPIRAL

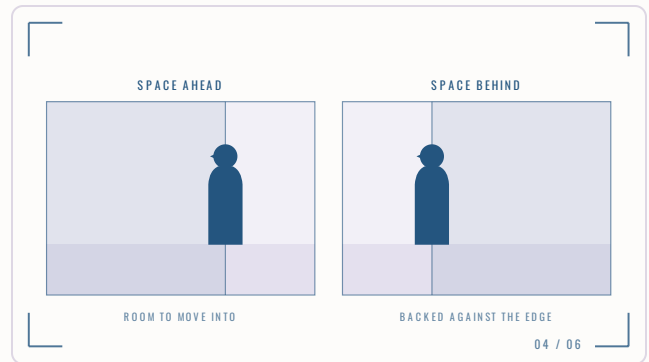
A rectangle is cut so the smaller part stands to the larger as the larger stands to the whole, a ratio of about 1 to 1.618. Square off the larger part, repeat inside what remains, and the corners trace a spiral tightening to a point where the subject sits. Painters have used the proportion for centuries; whether filmmakers aim for it or simply land near it is an argument nobody has ever won.



DEAD CENTRE

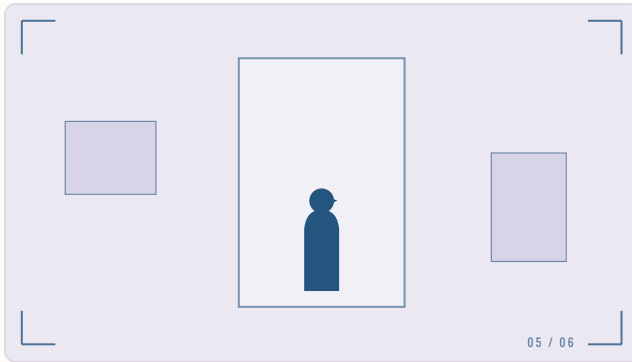
The subject sits on the frame's vertical axis and the picture is built to match on both sides of it. To spot it, find the vanishing point — where the lines of the room run to — and check whether it is dead in the middle with the same shapes left and right.

The Shining · Moonrise Kingdom · Mommy



LOOKING ROOM

The subject sits off centre and the empty part of the frame is set on the side they face or move toward. Reverse it and that space collects behind them instead. To spot it, find which side the gap is on, then which way the head is turned. Ahead reads as room to move into; behind reads as backed against the edge.



FRAME IN FRAME

A second frame is built inside the first out of whatever is in the shot: a doorway, a window, a mirror, an arch, a corridor. To spot it, look for a hard-edged rectangle of its own around the subject, with the picture outside it darker or cropped away. It makes the person inside smaller and the room tighter.

The Searchers · Carol · In the Mood for Love



NEGATIVE SPACE

The subject takes up a small part of the frame and the rest is left unbroken — sky, wall, water, fog, a bare room. To spot it, measure by eye how much of the picture carries no detail at all, and where the subject has been placed inside it. Past a certain point the emptiness stops being background and starts reading as weight.

Most films use several of these in a single scene. What marks a filmmaker is which one they reach for when it matters.

WHY THESE FILMS

Part Two starts with the most basic decision in filmmaking: where to put the camera, and what to leave out. Both films throw away the rule of thirds, one to show you a perfect world, the other to hide a private one.

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S FILM FORUM

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Criterion, the BFI, TCM, the Design Museum, Variety and Smith's Remarks on Rural Scenery (1797). Where sources disagree, the

disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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